



Finishing act: Sahil Lotra's century on the final day denied Karnataka any chance of coming back into the game.

day three to send back Test batters Rahul and Karun, and this edition's top-scorer R. Smaran. Karun and Smaran, in fact, fell for ducks, with the former cleaned up and the latter caught behind.

The usually flashy Abdul Samad added a dose of solidity to his batting to total 748 runs, the highest for his outfit. He scored at a strike rate of 69 — subdued by his standards, but still the highest among the nine batters who scored more than 700 runs this campaign.

In Dogra, 41, the squad found the perfect fulcrum. This was Dogra's second year with J&K, and being from Himachal Pradesh, he proved to be the perfect agent to amalgamate players from different parts of the Union Territory and

improve the dressing-room atmosphere, which used to be perilous once.

Dogra delivered with the bat too, scoring 637 runs, including centuries against Mumbai and Delhi. He also crossed 10,000 Ranji Trophy runs to become only the second man to do so after Mumbai legend and former India opener Wasim Jaffer.

While these men held the side together across the entirety of the campaign, J&K found custom-made heroes for specific match situations too.

On the eve of the final, the team lost experienced batter Shubham Khajuria and upcoming all-rounder Vanshaj Sharma to injuries. But the replacements, Qamran Iqbal and Sahil Lotra, both excelled, scoring fine second-innings centuries to shut the door on Karnataka.

Shubham Pundir, who had accumulated just 205 runs leading into the all-important fixture, made a

classy 121, while Yawer Hassan chose the summit clash to reach his highest score of the season — 88. All of which contributed to J&K making 584 runs, the most it had in a single innings in 2025-26.

Much of the credit for J&K's ascent has rightly been given to the BCCI sub-committee that took over the affairs of the Jammu & Kashmir Cricket Association in 2021. Current BCCI president Mithun Manhas was part of that grouping before he switched to the top cricketing job in the country. The Jammu-born former Delhi captain — who also turned out for J&K in 2015-16 and 2016-17 — was a constant presence in Hubballi as he witnessed history being made.

"It's been a long journey," said Manhas. "The association before us tried their level best. But the real game-changer happened in 2021. We used to get a lot of flak way back because the system was such.

There used to be a quota of eight